



HOUSE OF COMMONS

LONDON SW1A 0AA

Cllr Jim Martin
Leader of Folkestone and Hythe District Council
Civic Centre
Castle Hill Avenue
Folkestone
CT20 2QY

Our Ref: TV14084

3 June 2026

Dear Jim,

Designating Princes Parade a Local Nature Reserve

I hope you are well. I recently met with Mr Austin Meakin, who lives in Hythe, who asked me about the possibility of turning Princes Parade into a nature reserve. Nature reserves are managed areas of land that protect wildlife, habitats and natural features. He has raised the idea with other local residents who are very supportive of this idea.

Knowing the beauty of that area and the commitment of local residents to it, I am writing to say that I, too, am wholly supportive of the idea of turning Princes Parade into a local nature reserve and would dearly love to see this happen.

I would therefore like Folkestone & Hythe District Council to give serious consideration to the feasibility of designating Princes Parade a Local Nature Reserve such as by using its powers in section 21 of the National Parks and Access to the Countryside Act 1949 to do so.

Under that statutory provision, the Council has the power to provide and manage nature reserves, subject to consultation with Natural England. There appears to be a clear basis for the Council to explore this option. Government guidance – accessible here <https://www.gov.uk/guidance/create-and-manage-local-nature-reserves> – explains that local authorities may declare local nature reserves where they control the land, whether by ownership, lease or agreement. It also states that suitable sites may include natural green space as well as brownfield or other artificial sites where they are locally important for wildlife, geology, education or enjoyment.

This seems especially pertinent at Princes Parade. The Council's own public materials state that there is currently no further activity planned for the previous development scheme, that you have committed to "proper conversations" with the community about restoring the site's biodiversity and future, and that a majority of respondents to the Council's 2025 survey supported maintaining the current open space and encouraging biodiversity.

Against that background, I would be grateful if you would consider whether the Council could begin a formal feasibility exercise on designation of Princes Parade as a Local Nature Reserve.

Having regard to the large volumes of work already undertaken by the Council in relation to the site it would also assist to consider:

- what implications arise from the site's planning history and any current or proposed Local Plan allocations;
- whether current ecological assessments would be sufficient to support a designation;
- whether the Council's landholding and present control of the site are sufficient to support the designation process described in the Government guidance;
- whether partners such as Kent Wildlife Trust, local community groups, and Hythe Town Council could assist with management planning, biodiversity objectives, public access and community participation, all of which are contemplated by the guidance.

I should be grateful if you would let me know whether the Council is willing to examine this proposal, and if so what process and timetable you envisage for doing so. Given the evident public interest in the future of Princes Parade, I believe a careful and transparent consideration of Local Nature Reserve designation would be both timely and constructive. I am happy to meet to discuss these matters in more detail.

As the above guidance shows, the first step is to inform Natural England to say that you want to declare a local nature reserve. This would need to include a management plan covering matters including the reasons for selecting the site, biodiversity management, community participation, visitor management, and costs and funding arrangements, together with a boundary map. It may therefore be sensible for the Council first to scope those requirements and determine what further evidence or partnership work would be needed before any formal decision is taken.

Yours sincerely

A handwritten signature in cursive script, reading 'Tony Vaughan'.

Tony Vaughan KC MP
Member of Parliament for Folkestone, Hythe & Romney Marsh